that he had advanced Rs 3 lakh to the company.[17] The reference is possibly to the sum total of the money that had been advanced by the Mandayam family over the past year or so.

In April 1910, the CID reported that the company was ‘hopelessly insolvent’. New boilers in Bombay, meant to replace the old, unviable ones were seized by a creditor. With court decrees against the company being passed on all sides, SSNCo was redoubling its efforts to raise subscriptions, the promises for which ‘can never be fulfilled’, the report remarked with satisfaction, adding for good measure the unfounded accusation that the company was ‘a swindling concern’.[18]

In the first week of April, Pirojshaw Manackjee and D.K. Engineer, two Parsis from the Bombay shipping world, arrived in Tuticorin. Received at the railway station by S. Parthasarathy, their arrival could not have been a good augury. While Manackjee left for Colombo soon—S.D. Krishna Aiyangar was already there—and returned to Tuticorin only on 10 April,[19] he was to be followed by D.K. Engineer soon after. The purpose of the visit could only have been to salvage what little was left.[20] Later, it was said that these two were to take charge of the *Lawoe* and run it between Colombo and Kakinada.[21] We can surmise that the company was trying to keep the operations going, even as efforts were on to sell the assets.

The police continued to be relentless even when the company was on its knees. In early April, Ponnuranga Mudaliar, a police officer of the rank of deputy superintendent, was entrusted with the task of making inquiries about SSNCo. The intelligence collected was rich. A badly-in-need-of-repair *Gallia*, it was estimated, would require at least Rs 1 lakh to make it seaworthy. Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Company of Bombay had made an offer of Rs 1.5 lakh that also included the replacement boilers lying in Bombay. There was a better offer of Rs 2 lakh for the *Lawoe*, whose charges amounted to Rs 1,30,000. Overall, Ponnuranga Mudaliar reported, the company’s liabilities stood at Rs 4.5 lakh with the top creditors being Pandithurai Thevar (Rs 50,000), B.K. Ramaier (Rs 55,000), S. Parthasarathy (Rs 50,000); and a further Rs 75,000 being owed to various